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CART263 Creative Computation II

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Project 2 Artist Statement

Project URL: <https://philippe-bn.github.io/cart263/projects/project-2/>

Introduction

This piece is titled *Escapism*, and it is an interactive web experience built with Three.js. It explores the theme of fantasy through a simulated 3D environment in which the user¹ can navigate. By restricting the affordances² of our environment to only spatial displacement within it, the user is limited to a passive experience, like an intruder into this virtual world. Through this highly aestheticized dreamscape, the viewer witnesses “life” as it is simulated by algorithms, a window into a world which does not exist, an escape into a Secondary World.

Context

Drawing from Tolkien’s understanding of escapism as a function of fantasy³, *Escapism* is a response to the oppressive nature of contemporary systems. The escapist fantasies that are meant to help us cope with this reality have been co-opted: slop games with addictive mechanics saturate the video game offering on platforms like Roblox, Steam or Nintendo eShop (McDevitt, 2025). Directly affected by this even in the process of making this piece (*figure 1*), we offer an alternative:

¹ In the context of our experience, the term “user” (which lacks a passive, appreciative dimensionality) will be used interchangeably with the terms “viewer” (which lacks an active dimensionality) and “visitor” (which is defined by its spatiality but not its capacity for interaction).

² By “affordance” we refer to James J. Gibson’s definition of the term: “The affordances of the environment are what it offers the animal, what it provides or furnishes, either for good or ill” (Gibson, 1979).

³ In J. R. R. Tolkien’s 1947 essay “On Fairy Stories”, this is also referred to as “Escape”; “It is part of the essential malady of such days— producing the desire to escape, not indeed from life, but from our present time and self-made misery— that we are acutely conscious both of the ugliness of our works, and of their evil” (Tolkien, 1947).

a meditative experience focused similarly on provoking a pleasing experience for the visitor, an escapist fantasy without exploitation through monetization or required interaction.

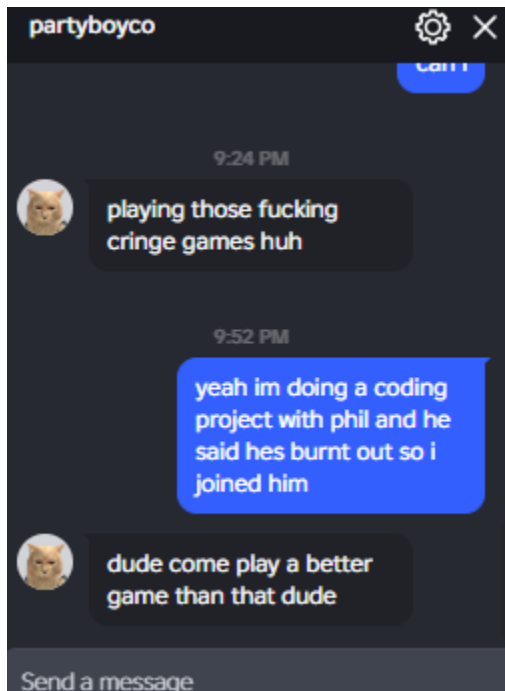


Figure 1. Roblox, chat screen grab. In the process of creating this piece we found ourselves falling for the “slop” escapist fantasy games on Roblox (Macknofsky, 2026).

Intention

The intention is to situate the user in a virtual environment: the user should be able to interact with the environment through simplified controls with minimized friction. The menu displayed once the experience begins is meant to didactically mediate this with the user. The user is then free to explore as they will, to fly amongst the flamingos (*figure 2*) or sit on a hillside (*figure 3*), to dive deep in a ravine or to follow a specific bird’s flight path. These freedoms afforded to the user within the limited context of the experience serve to frame the aesthetic qualities meant to be transmitted to the viewer (*figure 4*).



Figure 2. *Escapism*, screen grab. A sense of the Sublime is provoked from scenes in which the multitude of birds in front of the colourful sky gain an awe-inspiring aesthetic quality unique to natural environments (Beauchemin, Macknofsky, 2026).



Figure 3. *Escapism*, screen grab. The detailing of the minuscule, frail flowers perched on the hillside give the environment's beauty depth and complexity (Beauchemin, Macknofsky, 2026).



Figure 4. Escapism, screen grab. The emergent quality of the flock of birds taking flight makes for a sublime, appeasing, beautiful experience (Beauchemin, Macknofsky, 2026).

Implementation

The project started as a continuation of *Aquarium*, Beauchemin's Project 1 for this course (figure 5). The initial goal was to bring the flocking dynamic of fish into a 3D space.

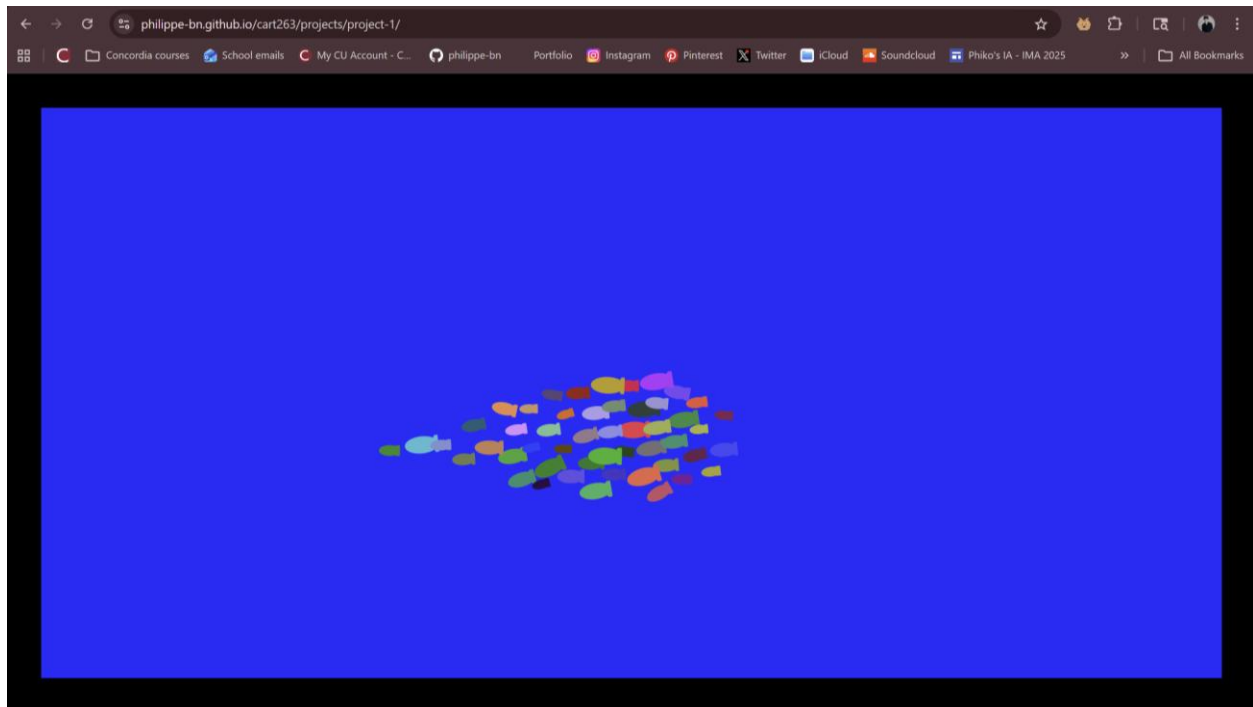


Figure 5. *Aquarium*, interactive web experience. Altered flocking dynamics make the fish follow the user's mouse (Beauchemin, 2026).

Using the framework established in Task 7 which used modules, imports and exports, Beauchemin adapted the Fish class to use a GLTF model sourced online instead of a custom div and adapted the behaviours to work in 3D space. The movement was difficult to replicate using vectorial calculations in 3D space, and it was only when we found the Three.js examples that we changed our mind about where this project would go. First, the *geometry / terrain* example (figure 6) demonstrated it was possible to leverage the Three.js library to create procedural terrain geometry, using noise, as we had initially tried to implement using Perlin Noise with the suggestions of Google Gemini. The example's code was implemented and allowed for the build of a seabed in an underwater environment, with fish passing through spotlights and shimmering briefly against a dark blue background. Second, the *gpgpu / birds / gltf* example (figure 7) demonstrated it was possible to create flocking dynamics in 3D space, which could serve to replace the issues we were having, and inspired Macknofsky to want to bring the project into a more aerial environment. Building upon the Fish class, Macknofsky built a Butterfly class that would serve to populate an environment with a procedurally generated terrain. Iterating colours and adding in a

colourful sky, the environment quickly took shape (*figure 8*) – we decided to add the flamingos in to see what it would look like and ultimately decided to keep them as they fit our fantasy theme.

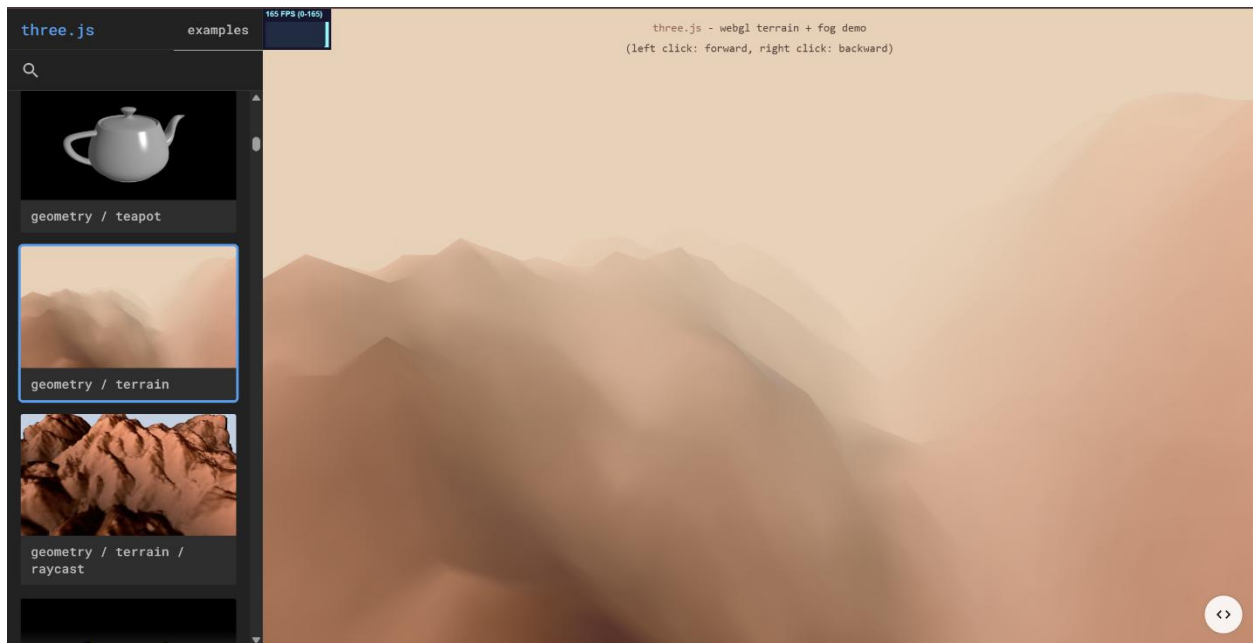


Figure 6. geometry / terrain, Three.js example. We loved the idea of using noise for procedural terrain generation⁴ and liked the aesthetic of fog (Beauchemin, Macknofsky, 2026).



⁴ This was an idea that was present in Daniel Schiffman's *The Nature of Code*, the foundation for Aquarium, Beauchemin's Project 1 that preceded this (Schiffman, 2024).

Figure 7. gpgpu / birds / gltf, Three.js example. We found this simulation to be implementing flocking extremely fluidly and Macknofsky was particularly drawn to the aerial quality of it (Beauchemin, Macknofsky, 2026).

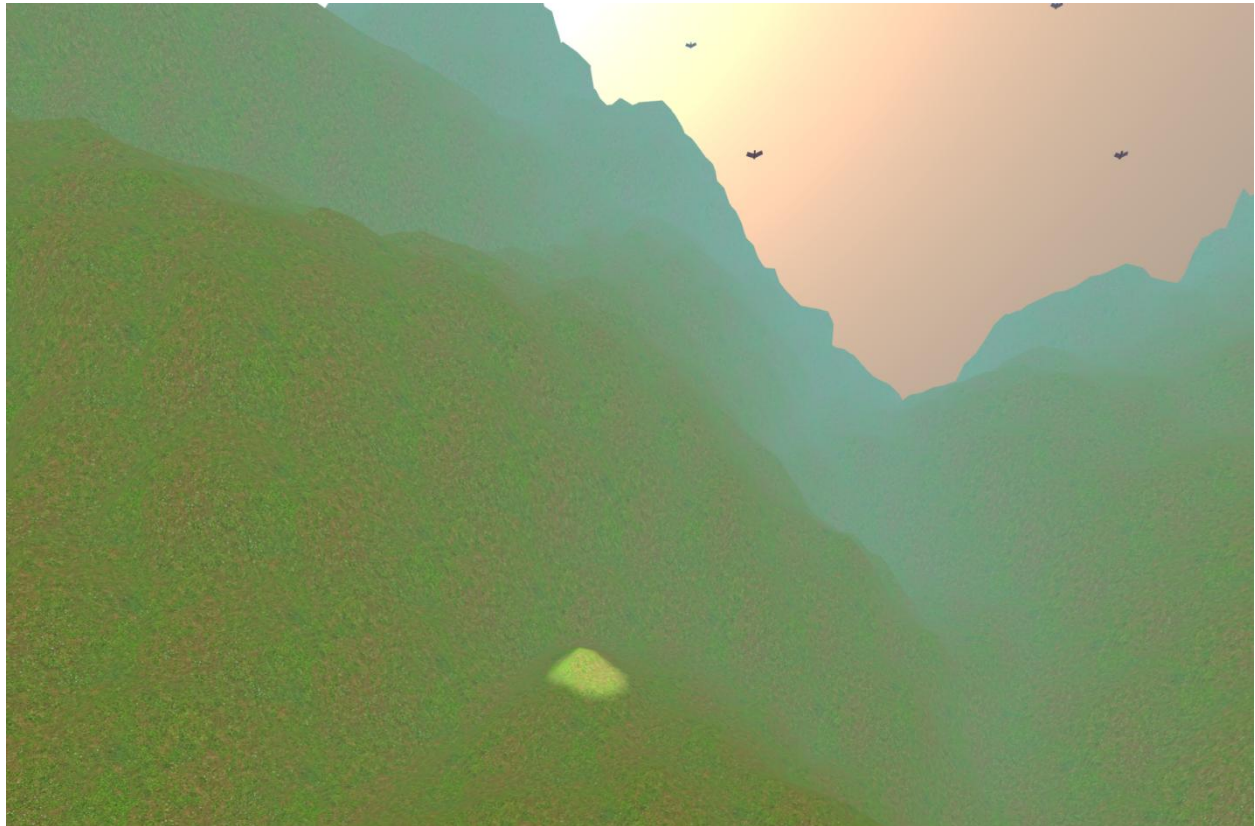


Figure 8. Escapism (early version), screen grab. Static butterflies were placed within an aerial environment, with the ground and sky having a greenish hue, a spot of light still shining on the ground from the previous iteration (Beauchemin, Macknofsky, 2026).

Conclusion

Escapism invites its user to explore its fantasy landscape: to be in awe of the beauty of nature, while remaining in control of their body. The piece exists as a virtual world, allowing the viewer to escape temporarily their everyday. Mathematical rules come together to create an emergent sense of life and of reproduction of natural processes. The Three.js code library is exploited to be able to build out a 3D world with physics, movement and complex mechanics.

Works Cited

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